reluctant to join the nonproliferation treaty and any comprehensive test ban that did not include China.[154]

So Brzezinski saw subsequent developments that China and India were "genuinely interested" in improving relations, despite the Soviet and border constraints, as a good sign.[155] In February 1978, Desai said that India would do nothing to "spoil the improvement" in relations.[156] And Vajpayee played down the prime minister's suggestion that China withdrawing from Indian territory was a precondition for any progress. He indicated that India would maintain its territorial claims, but also seek an improvement in relations.[157] Subsequently, Deng made a conciliatory statement at a press conference, and a Chinese trade delegation traveled to India. Then a Chinese goodwill delegation visited in March and invited Vajpayee to visit China. The delegation head, moreover, publicly agreed with Desai that the border issue should be settled peacefully. Delhi also noted that Chinese Communist Party chairman Hua Guofeng's report to the National People's Congress included positive words about the developing rapprochement.[158]

Around that spring, Beijing started signaling a greater receptiveness to American overtures as well.[159] Then the domestic climate in the US became more amenable to a Brzezinski trip to China. There were also greater global and regional imperatives for discussions with Beijing. Moscow's attempt to encourage the idea of a special US-Soviet relationship was worrying China —though it did please India, which favored détente.[160] Moreover, a Soviet-backed coup in Afghanistan had made not just Pakistan but China more important too. After all, Beijing shared American concern that instability in Afghanistan and Pakistan could create space for Moscow.[161]

On Various Visits

When Brzezinski traveled to Beijing that May, South Asia was a major subject of discussion. Huang noted that stability there would limit Soviet inroads. The two sides agreed that there had been a "turn for the better" with the Desai government, even though it was not anti-Soviet. Huang felt Delhi's "dependency" on Moscow would prevent any speedy change and expected Soviet officials to try to stall Sino-Indian reconciliation. Brzezinski stressed that the best way to decrease Indian dependence on the Soviet Union was for China and the US to offer India better ties. This was particularly crucial given greater Soviet activism in the region, as evident in